Not a Genuine Black Man

By Brian Copeland

BRIAN: **(xi-xii)** Although I'm a stand-up comic by trade, I also do a radio show for a talk station in San Francisco. *(begins to settle back into his office)* I'd been out on the road for a couple of weeks, and when I got back into the station, I had all this mail piled up. In talk radio, mail generally comes to you from two sources: old ladies and kooks. That's it. Nobody else writes you. The upside is that it makes the mail easy to sort. *(going through his mail)*

So I'm going through the pile. Old lady. Old lady. Death threat. Old lady. Ooh, here's a good one. Death threat from an old lady.

Then I come across one that's typed . . . I mean typed on an actual typewriter. No return address. Local postmark. Addressed to me. I open it, taking out an unsigned sheet that reads: "As an African American, I am disgusted every time I hear your voice because . . ." *(trails off as he finishes the sentence silently; tries again aloud.)* "As an

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African American, I am disgusted every time I hear your voice because ***YOU*** are not a genuine black man."

INTRODUCTION

It has often been said that comedians deal with pain through humor. They laugh so they don't have to cry. This was especially true for comedian Brian Copeland. When he was eight, his mother moved his family from Oakland to San Leandro, hoping to escape her abusive husband. Now, keep in mind, that in the early 1970s, San Leandro was 99.99% white and considered one of the most racist enclaves in the nation. The result. He was labeled his whole life - an outsider in his own community based on the color of his skin and an outsider within his race for not being black enough.

Brian spent his adult years trying to leave behind his painful childhood. But an anonymous letter ultimately forces him question his own identity.

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BRIAN: **(xii-xiv)** *(picks up reading again)* **"...** not a genuine black man." Why do people say that to me? Actually, people have said that to me throughout my life. I don't even know what that means. Is it how I dress? Is it how I talk? Is it how my machine is set to TiVo *(could replace with Stream)* ***Frasier***?

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If you're talking about pigment, you can tell by looking at me that I am clearly black. But if you're talking about some cultural delineation, I don't know. I can't swim. That's black.

(Thinks for a moment) I'm a Democrat. That's black. I never understood black Republicans. To me, a black joining the Republican Party is like a deer joining the National Rifle Association.

(xvii) Whatever the answer is, any confusion I have about race, any misunderstanding I have about ethnicity, any confusion I have about blackness . . . is my mother's fault. [When I was 8-years-old she moved my family to San Leandro, CA]

(Pg 12) San Leandro borders Oakland, to the south. Oakland was nearly half black. San Leandro (on the other hand) was 99.99 percent white. Ninety-nine point ninety-nine percent! Ivory Soap looked at that number and went, "WOW!" **(Pg 15)** To this day, I don't know how much my mother knew about San Leandro and its reputation when she moved us there. [The only reason we moved was to get away from Sylvester, my father.]

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(Pg 8) He was crazy. I never knew what he was going to say or do. He used to mess with my head.

SYLVESTER: Hey Brian, come here . . . . Knock, knock.

BRIAN: Who's there?

SYLVESTER: *(slapping Brian on the head violently)* What did I tell you about answering the door when you don't know who's on the other side of it?

BRIAN: Once when I was five, I sniffed in a way that Sylvester thoughts was directed at him. He grabbed my nose and pinched it so hard that it was bruised for a month. **(Pg 7)** He was always doing things like that. [Anyway] **(Pg 19)** my mother moved us.

(Pg 95) My mother worked very hard at learning "the white man's culture," from her conversion to Catholicism *(crosses himself)* to her switch to the Republican party. She tried to assimilate in any and every way possible. Her philosophy was that while we may not look like them, we could act like them if that's what it took to be accepted; if that was what we had to do to succeed.

(Pg 131) My childhood was a confusing barrage of mixed messages. On the one hand, Mom would say, "Be proud

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that you're black, because black is beautiful. Then, when we acted up, she would say, "Act your age, not your color," as if immaturity, rambunctiousness and negative behavior were "black" things. *(beat as memories pour back in)* **(Pg 19)** My mother moved us.

MOM: **(Pg 20)** It'll be okay, honey. Remember you're the man of the house now.

BRIAN: Maybe it would be okay. Sylvester wasn't there . . . How bad could it be? [until he found us]

MOM: **(Pg 171)** Your father . . . He's coming home.

BRIAN: **(Pg 195-196)** [I remember] *(Voice shifts to that of a young boy as Brian re-lives the event in actions and words)* I came home from school and the apartment appeared to be empty. Mom and Grandma must still be at work. That left the question, where was Sylvester? Actually, that was always the question. At that moment, a craving took over my body. *(opening the cabinet and getting a huge bowl and box of cereal)* I wanted a great big salad bowl filled to the brim with Cap'n Crunch. Isn't that the best after school snack in the world? It's sweet and crunchy . . . What more can a kid ask for? *(BUMP, BUMP) (Brian looks around perplexed)* There it was

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again. *(BUMP, BUMP)* It was coming from my mother's room. I took the stairs two at a time. *(BUMP)* I got to the doorway of my mother's room and there I saw him. *(Actor assumes the role of Sylvester who is repeatedly slamming mother's head against the wall) (BUMP, BUMP, BUMP) (Brian reacts)*

It was Sylvester, my mother's head gripped firmly in his hands, banging her skull against the wall. *(BUMP, BUMP)* I ran back downstairs into the kitchen. What to do? What to do? Then I saw it, there in the sink. The shiny blade of Grandma's butcher knife. It was the sharpest knife in the house. I grabbed it and took it upstairs. The bumping had stopped. I stood in the doorway. *(knife pointed at Sylvester)* LET HER GO! Let her go or I swear to God I will stick this knife in your heart!

SYLVESTER: *(Turns and smiles in amusement)* What? You a man now? Do you know I will kill you? **(Pg 9)** N****, quit sticking you lip out at me!

BRIAN: **(Pg 197)** Yes, I'm the man of the house and I want you to get out! *(shaking with tears running down his*

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face) Let her go! *(to audience)* He reached for me with both hands. I was watching him every second but I never saw him coming. *(rises on tiptoe, as if Sylvester has him be the throat; he struggles to loosen Sylvester's grip)* Before I knew it, he had his hands around my throat. **(Pg 9)** My father strangling me **(Pg 199)** My mother screamed. [But] her screech was broken by . . .

POLICE: Police!

BRIAN: With that, Sylvester took his hands from around my neck. I gasped for air. He shook his head in disgust. He was disgusted! He pushed past me and walked out the door into the hallway. I could hear him talking to the police as I closed the bedroom door. [And just like that he was gone]

(Pg 167-169) If you go to the street corners of East Oakland or Detroit or Compton, or just about any other urban area with a large black population, you'll find all these guys selling crack, and all of these guys with five babies by five different women, none of whom they're supporting. Yet never once has anybody ever accused them of not being a "genuine black man."

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(Crosses to pick up the letter that started all this) Is that what the black person who sent me [this] letter expects me to be? They want me to be Sylvester? I have to be the worst possible stereotype or I'm not "keeping it real?" No.

(Emotional level starts quiet but builds to one of extremely strong emotion) I have this fantasy. I'd track down the writer's address and go to his house and get in his face and say: I owe you an apology. I'm sorry. I'm sorry that I don't deal drugs. I'm sorry for wanting more and not less. I'm sorry that all of my children were born into wedlock and that I support them. I'm sorry that I help them with their homework and that I don't tell them that getting good grades is "acting white". I'm sorry for wanting to live in a neighborhood where I'm not kept awake at night by gunshots, sirens and screams. I'm sorry that I look so shitty in an orange jumpsuit that I'm not going to prison for anybody. I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry, *(Rips ups the letter and he is overcome with emotion)* I'M SORRY!

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(Pg 231) *(softly)* Wow. **(Pg 169)** I'm sorry. **(Pg 231)** I'm a firm believer that most things in this world happen for a reason. **(Pg 243-244)** When all is said and done, I AM a Genuine Black Man – because I am resilient. I'm still here. I [survived] harassment, schoolyard bullies and Sylvester and bouts of crippling depression. I am still here. *(tears)* That's what being black in America is truly about: resilience.

(Pg 245) People sometimes ask me if my mother made the right choice moving us to San Leandro. All I can say in response is, "It's my hometown." I am proud and I am at peace. Genuinely.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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